

STAGE TWELVE • LEADERSHIP

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Twelve • Leadership

PURPOSE

Leadership is fundamentally relational — you cannot fully evaluate your own coaching questions, feedback delivery, or stakeholder framing from the inside. This makes Stage Twelve one of the stages where group adaptation adds the most genuine value: several skills here only reveal their real quality once tested against an actual listener.

This document adapts seven FIRSTS across all three sections of Stage Twelve into pair, small-group, or role-play formats. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual reflection or planning first, and the group version tests or deepens it.

Several of these use realistic-but-fictional scenarios (a prepared conflict, a hypothetical direct report) rather than participants' actual, personal leadership situations — this keeps the practice concrete without requiring anyone to expose a real, sensitive workplace situation to the group.

The Seven Adapted Exercises

FIRST P2

Leadership Style Assessment — Peer Mirror

TIME: +15 min beyond solo reflection

1. After individual reflection, pairs share their self-identified natural tendency with each other.
2. Partner responds honestly: based on how this person has shown up in the program so far, does that tendency match what they've actually observed?
3. Discuss any genuine gap between self-perception and outside observation.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This directly addresses the Common Misconception flagged in this FIRST — self-perception checked only against itself rarely catches a real blind spot. An outside observer, even one who's only seen limited behavior, often does.

FIRST P6

Team Goal Set — Silent Restate

TIME: +10 min beyond individual drafting

1. If real teams are present, the “leader” states the goal once, then every other team member privately writes their own understanding of it without discussion.
2. All restatements are revealed simultaneously.
3. The team discusses any genuine difference and agrees on one final, shared statement.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Simultaneous, not sequential, reveal is what makes this work — sequential answers let later speakers anchor to the first one rather than giving a genuinely independent read.

FIRST P15

Person Coached — Live Coaching Round

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Partner A briefly describes a real, current, low-stakes problem (not a crisis).
2. Partner B may only ask questions — no advice, no solutions, no “have you tried...”.
3. After 5 minutes, Partner A shares whether they got closer to their own solution, and Partner B reflects on how hard it was not to just give the answer.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Most people default to advice-giving almost immediately; this exercise makes the discipline of pure coaching viscerally difficult to maintain, which is exactly the point.

FIRST P16

Constructive Feedback Given as a Leader — Feedback Sandwich Stress-Test

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Each participant drafts one piece of constructive feedback for a real (or realistic hypothetical) direct report.
2. In pairs, deliver the feedback aloud to your partner, who receives it in character as the direct report.
3. Partner gives one honest reaction: did it feel like the improvement area came through clearly, or did it get lost in softening?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Feedback that reads as appropriately balanced on paper often reveals itself as either too soft or too blunt once actually spoken aloud to a real listener — this catches that gap before it happens with a real direct report.

FIRST P18

Conflict Handled as a Leader — Mediator Fishbowl

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Two volunteers role-play a realistic (not personal) team conflict; a third volunteer plays the leader mediating it.
2. Everyone else observes silently, each assigned one thing to watch: did the leader stay neutral, did both sides feel heard, was a genuine resolution reached?
3. Debrief as a full group: what specific leadership behaviors made the mediation work or struggle?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Use a prepared, realistic-but-fictional conflict scenario rather than asking anyone to reenact a genuine personal dispute — this keeps the exercise safely hypothetical while still being concrete enough to learn from.

FIRST P23

Stakeholder Influence Exercise — Pitch Relay

TIME: +20 min beyond solo prep

1. Each participant prepares one real pitch and identifies two different stakeholders with different priorities.
2. In small groups, deliver the pitch once framed for Stakeholder A, then again reframed for Stakeholder B, to two different listeners in the group.
3. Listeners give one piece of feedback each: did the framing genuinely feel tailored, or was it the same pitch with a different opening line?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Saying both versions out loud back-to-back makes it immediately obvious whether the tailoring is genuine or superficial — a gap that's much harder to notice when only imagined on paper.

FIRST P27

Leadership Feedback Received — Anonymous Round

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. If real teams or long-standing groups are present, distribute anonymous index cards or an anonymous digital form.
2. Each person writes one honest piece of feedback for the person they most recently worked under or with in any leadership capacity, including within this workshop.
3. Facilitator collects and redistributes (or shares digitally) without attribution.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is a genuine, live demonstration of exactly what FIRST P27 asks participants to seek out on their own — anonymity is what makes the feedback here, and in real life, more honest than a named request would produce.